



The Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory (JCRT)

3.1 |

‘Misrecognition of the Limits’: Bourdieu’s Religious Capital and Social Transformation

Lora Stone

Figure 1

Figure 1: Figure 1

Stone - "Misrecognition of the Limits" - JCRT 3.1

"Misrecognition of the Limits": Bourdieu's *Religious Capital* and Social Transformation

Lora Stone

University of New Mexico

Political process models attempt to address the interaction between a social movement and the larger social environment, and treat society as a complex system of power relations through which a group may be denied or granted access to power. With the political process model, social movements are explained in terms of broad economic, demographic, and political processes that determine not only the context of a social movement, but how a movement develops or dissipates. Expanding this model, recent works in the study of social movements and social transformation have presented analyses that not only address the structural forces contributing to social movements, but include an analysis of their cultural and symbolic elements as well. However, political process theories do not explain many aspects of those social movements that occur *within* institutions. Concepts drawn from the work of Pierre Bourdieu can contribute to an increased understanding of the dynamics of social movements occurring within institutions, especially those organized around or emerging from religious interest. In the following paragraphs I examine various political process theories, discuss Bourdieu's concepts of *habitus*, *field*, *symbolic power*, and *religious capital*, and consider the case of a social movement within an institution: the women's ordination movement in the Catholic Church.

Introduction

Social Movements As Political Process

From The Work Of Bourdieu

*Habitus**Field**Symbolic Power**Cultural Capital*

The Ordination of Women

*Conclusion and Continuance***Figure 1. Political process model.****Figure 2. Challenge within a field.**

Figure 2

Figure 2: Figure 2

As to social transformation, whether occurring as a field challenge between orthodoxy and heresy, or through challenges mounted by social movements against institutions, it seems culture is an important factor in the success of a movement. All social relations are supported by a system of shared understandings, and these understandings are shaped by code as both objectified culture and practiced culture. The success of a social movement, then, may depend on how well cultural biases are reshaped, and to what extent misrecognition is recognized.

References

- Alberoni, Francesco. 1984. *Movement and Institution*. New York: Columbia University Press.
- Berger, Peter. 1967. *The Sacred Canopy: Elements of a Sociological Theory of Religion*. New York: Doubleday.
- Boff, Leonardo. 1999. "The Uncompleted Vision of Vatican II: The Church-Hierarchy of People of God?" Pp. 31-39 in *The Non-Ordination of Women and the Politics of Power*, edited by Elisabeth Schüssler Fiorenza and Hermann H'ring. London: SCM Press.
- Bourdieu, Pierre. 1977. "Symbolic Power." Pp. 112-119 in *Identity and Structure*, edited by D. Gleeson. Driffield: Nafferton Books.
- . 1977a. *Outline of a Theory of Practice*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- . 1979. *Algeria 1960*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- . 1984. *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*. Cambridge: Harvard University Press.
- . 1987. "What Makes a Social Class? On the Theoretical and Practical Existence of Groups." *Berkeley Journal of Sociology* 32:1-18.
- . 1989. "Social Space and Symbolic Power." *Sociological Theory* 7.1: 14-25.
- . 1990. *The Logic of Practice*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.
- . 1991. "Genesis and Structure of the Religious Field." Pp. 1-44 in *Comparative Social Research: Religious Institutions*, vol 13, edited by Craig Calhoun. Greenwich, CN.: JAI Press.
- . 1993. *The Field of Cultural Production*. New York: Columbia University Press.
- . 1993a. *Sociology in Question*. London: Sage Publications.
- . 1998. *Practical Reason: On Theory of Action*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.
- Bourdieu, Pierre, and Jean-Claude Passeron. 1977. *Reproduction in Education, Society and Culture*. London: Sage Publications.
- Bourdieu, Pierre, and Lo'c J. D. Wacquant. 1992. *An Invitation to Reflexive Sociology*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

- Chaves, Mark. 1997. *Ordaining Women: Culture and Conflict in Religious Organizations*. Cambridge: Harvard University Press.
- Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith. 1995. "Reply to the dubium concerning the teaching contained in the apostolic letter *Ordinatio Sacerdotalis*." *Origins* 25 (November 30, 1995): 400-403.
- Evans-Pritchard, E. 1962. *Nuer Religion*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.
- Fiorenza, Elisabeth Sch'ssler, and Hermann H'ring. 1999. "Introduction: They Can't Kill the Spirit." Pp. vii-x in *The Non-Ordination of Women and the Politics of Power*, edited by Elisabeth Sch'ssler Fiorenza and Hermann H'ring. London: SCM Press.
- Gould, Anthony. 1998. "Political Networks and the Local/National Boundary in the Whiskey Rebellion." In Hanagan, Moch, and te Brake (eds.), *Challenging Authority*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
- McAdam, Doug. 1982. *Political Process and the Development of Black Insurgency, 1930- 1970*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- McCarthy, John D., and Zald, Meyer. 1973. *The Trend of Social Movements in America*. Morristown: General Learning Press.
- Meyer-Wilmes, Hedwig. 1999. "The Diversity of Ministries in a Postmodern Church." Pp. 69-88 in *The Non-Ordination of Women and the Politics of Power*, edited by Elisabeth Sch'ssler Fiorenza and Hermann H'ring. London: SCM Press.
- National Coalition of American Nuns National Coalition of American Nuns. 1995. "This Teaching Cannot Be Infallible." Adopted by the NCAN Board, December 8, 1995.
- Raming, Ida. 1976. *The Exclusion of Women from the Priesthood: Divine Law or Sex Discrimination?* Metuchen, N.J.: Scarecrow Press.
- Snow, David A., Rochford, Burke E., Worden, Steven and Robert Benford. 1986. "Frame Alignment Processes, Micromobilization, and Movement Participation." *American Sociological Review* 51.3:463-481.
- Swartz, David. 1997. *Culture and Power: The Sociology of Pierre Bourdieu*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Sweeny, Terrance. 1992. *A Church Divided: The Vatican versus the American Catholics*. Buffalo, N.Y.: Prometheus Books.
- Swidler, Ann. 1986. "Culture and Action: Symbols and Strategies." *American Sociological Review* 51.3: 273-286.
- Tarrow, Sidney. 1994. *Power in Movement: Social Movements, Collective Action and Politics*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Tilly, Charles. 1978. *From Mobilization to Revolution*. New York: Random House.
- Tilly, Charles. 1988. "Social Movements, Old and New." In L. Reisberg (ed.), *Research in Social Movements, Conflict and Change*, vol.10. Greenwich, Conn.: JAI Press.
- Wallis, W. D. 1943. *Messiahs, Their Role in Civilization*. Washington, D.C.: American Council on Public Affairs.

Lora Stone is currently a doctoral student and an instructor in the Department of Sociology at the University of New Mexico. Her research interests include culture, religion, social movements, and theology.

Copyright © held by the author(s). 2001 Lora Stone. All rights reserved.
Updated 07/28/21.
jcr.org/archives/03.1/stone
